# COMMUNICATING THROUGH DISAGREEMENT

Moderator Guide | Ranger Mastery Program - Day 10

## A conversation about listening, constructive challenge, and shared progress.

Audience: Support Engineers, Rangers, Escalation Engineers, Technical Leads

Suggested duration: 90 minutes | 6-10 participants
Conversation only | No written activities

# 1. Top learnings and conversation purpose

**RMP Day 10 | Week 2: Structure ambiguity.** Explore RMP Day 10 through Lynne Hurdle and Madecraft's *Communicating through Disagreement*.

## Learning objectives - through conversation, participants will:

- **Normalize disagreement:** distinguish a different view from disrespect and identify the shared support outcome.
- **Understand before responding:** explore listening, assumptions, and the needs behind another person's position.
- **Challenge constructively:** discuss evidence and impact without attacking personality, status, or team identity.
- **Keep dialogue safe and useful:** consider emotional pressure, respectful boundaries, and when to pause or escalate.
- **Move forward without forced consensus:** explore clear decisions, ownership, and repair when people still disagree.

## Expected outcome

Participants leave with a shared view of disagreement as something to navigate rather than automatically avoid or win. They hear practical ways to understand different perspectives and preserve a customer outcome, even when full agreement is unavailable. There are **no written tasks, simulations, worksheets, tests, or required follow-up assignments**.

## Suggested 90-minute conversation

| Time | Conversation topic | Question at its heart |
|---|---|---|
| 0-8 | Welcome, objectives, and opening round | Where does this show up in our support work? |
| 8-20 | 1. Difference without an enemy | When does a different view help a support case, and when does it become unproductive? |
| 20-32 | 2. Listen for the need behind the position | How do we know we understand the other person's view before responding to it? |
| 32-44 | 3. Facts, interpretations, and assumptions | What helps us discover whether we disagree about the evidence or about what the evidence means? |
| 44-56 | 4. Challenge while preserving respect | How can we challenge a recommendation without making the person feel attacked? |
| 56-68 | 5. A decision without full agreement | How can a support team make a responsible next decision when people still disagree? |
| 68-80 | 6. Repair and future collaboration | What makes it easier to work together again after a tense disagreement? |
| 80-90 | Key takeaways and lessons learned | What changed or expanded our thinking? |

**Use:** a flexible route, not a questionnaire to finish. Open with one question and choose follow-ups as needed. Examples are conversation starters, not exercises. The six topics are original support adaptations, not a claimed sequence from the source.

# 2. Conversation: disagreement and listening

## Topic 1 | Difference without an enemy - 8-20 min

**Learning objective:** Separate disagreement from a threat to the relationship.

**Open the conversation:** *"When does a different view help a support case, and when does it become unproductive?"*

**Follow the conversation:**

- What shared outcome might be hidden behind different recommendations?
- How can urgency make a normal disagreement feel personal?
- What would change if we aimed to understand the difference rather than win?

**If a concrete example helps:** Two teams disagree about whether to investigate further or propose a mitigation. Ask: *What customer outcome could both be trying to protect, even if they recommend different actions?*

**If the discussion drifts:** *"Rather than choose the winning team, what common outcome and unresolved difference can we name?"*

**Learning point to draw out:** Disagreement is a normal part of working together. Naming the shared outcome can reduce the need to treat the other view as an opponent.

## Topic 2 | Listen for the need behind the position - 20-32 min

**Learning objective:** Explore curiosity without implying automatic agreement.

**Open the conversation:** *"How do we know we understand the other person's view before responding to it?"*

**Follow the conversation:**

- What might a repeated request reveal about a concern we have not understood?
- How can we check our understanding without sounding patronizing?
- What questions open the discussion rather than cross-examine the other person?

**If a concrete example helps:** A customer insists on an immediate call while the engineer wants to finish diagnostic work. Ask: *Is the underlying need reassurance, a decision, evidence, or something else? How might we find out?*

**If the discussion drifts:** *"Before deciding whether the request is reasonable, what do we still need to understand?"*

**Learning point to draw out:** Understanding a perspective is not the same as agreeing with it. Listening can reveal options that a debate about positions misses.

# 3. Conversation: evidence and respectful challenge

## Topic 3 | Facts, interpretations, and assumptions - 32-44 min

**Learning objective:** Make the basis of the disagreement visible.

**Open the conversation:** *"What helps us discover whether we disagree about the evidence or about what the evidence means?"*

**Follow the conversation:**

- Which parts of our account are direct observations and which are interpretations?
- How might teams have different time windows, case context, or success criteria?
- What would each side need to see to reconsider its view?

**If a concrete example helps:** One team sees a healthy aggregate dashboard while another hears ongoing customer failures. Ask: *Could both accounts be accurate for different scopes, and what clarification would matter before arguing about credibility?*

**If the discussion drifts:** *"Let us separate the observation from the conclusion before judging either position."*

**Learning point to draw out:** A disagreement can reflect missing or differently scoped information. Clarify evidence and assumptions before attributing bad intent.

## Topic 4 | Challenge while preserving respect - 44-56 min

**Learning objective:** Discuss language and boundaries when pressure rises.

**Open the conversation:** *"How can we challenge a recommendation without making the person feel attacked?"*

**Follow the conversation:**

- What changes when we describe impact instead of motives?
- How can we acknowledge emotion while staying clear about a constraint?
- When should a conversation pause or use an approved escalation route?

**If a concrete example helps:** On a bridge, someone says another team is blocking recovery. Ask: *How could the group return to the specific dependency and needed decision without accepting blame or escalating the personal criticism?*

**If the discussion drifts:** *"Let us describe the behavior or blocker, not speculate about the person's motives."*

**Learning point to draw out:** Respect does not require silent agreement or tolerating abuse. Address the issue clearly and follow organizational safety and conduct procedures when needed.

# 4. Conversation: decisions and repair

## Topic 5 | A decision without full agreement - 56-68 min

**Learning objective:** Explore progress when perspectives remain different.

**Open the conversation:** *"How can a support team make a responsible next decision when people still disagree?"*

**Follow the conversation:**

- Who has the relevant decision authority, and what input do they need?
- What risk, safeguard, or reassessment point could make the next step proportionate?
- How do we communicate the decision without pretending everyone endorsed it?

**If a concrete example helps:** Teams disagree about a proposed workaround while impact continues. Ask: *What approved decision route, evidence, risks, and review point would support progress without an unapproved change?*

**If the discussion drifts:** *"We do not need to force consensus. What decision is needed, who can make it, and how will it be reviewed?"*

**Learning point to draw out:** Progress may require an authorized decision, not unanimous agreement. Preserve concerns, clear ownership, and the normal technical safeguards.

## Topic 6 | Repair and future collaboration - 68-80 min

**Learning objective:** Consider what helps after a difficult exchange.

**Open the conversation:** *"What makes it easier to work together again after a tense disagreement?"*

**Follow the conversation:**

- What might need acknowledgment even if the technical decision was sound?
- How can we revisit a recurring friction point without reopening the personal argument?
- What team expectation would help the next disagreement stay constructive?

**If a concrete example helps:** An incident is resolved, but one engineer felt dismissed and avoids the other team afterward. Ask: *What acknowledgment or neutral follow-up could restore collaboration without forcing an apology or public reconciliation?*

**If the discussion drifts:** *"Instead of retrying the original argument, what would make the next interaction more respectful and effective?"*

**Learning point to draw out:** The relationship continues after the decision. Acknowledgment, clear expectations, and appropriate follow-up can support future cooperation without requiring identical views.

# 5. Moderator's guide: keep it a conversation

## Set the tone: opening eight minutes

Introduce the objectives and expected outcome. Say: *"This is a conversation, not an assessment. Different roles and regions will see this differently. Use fictional or anonymized work patterns, not customer details. You can pass, and I will make room for each voice."*

Use a short opening round: *"Where does disagreement most often slow progress in support: technical interpretation, urgency, ownership, or communication? A phrase or short example is enough."* Invite everyone once, allowing about 20-30 seconds each. Do not solve each case. Name one or two shared themes, then move to Topic 1.

## Make participation broad, not forced

Aim for **6-10 participants**. With a larger group, use more round tables or allow more time. Rotate the first voice, invite different roles and shifts, and allow silence for thought. Everyone receives a genuine invitation, not an obligation to disclose or defend their ability.

| What you notice | A useful moderator phrase |
|---|---|
| The same people answer first | "Thank you. Before adding more, let us hear from someone who has not spoken on this topic." |
| A quieter participant has not had space | "Would you like to add a view from your role or shift? Passing is completely fine." |
| A speaker runs long | "Let me pause there to make room for others. What is the main point you would like us to take from that?" |
| The conversation becomes a detailed case review | "We do not need to settle the past argument. What difference, assumption, or communication pattern does it illustrate?" |
| A person or region is blamed | "Let us examine the work conditions and behaviors, not judge the person or team. What would help any engineer here?" |
| Participants disagree | "What is each view protecting, and what do we understand differently after hearing both?" |
| Discussion moves to an unrelated issue | "That matters, but it takes us away from today's objective. Can we connect it to this question, or leave it for the appropriate channel?" |
| There is silence | "Take a moment. Would the fictional support example help? What might be difficult in that situation?" |

## Bridge between topics

Reflect neutrally: *"I am hearing [theme], with a different experience around [difference]. Have I understood? That connects to our next question about [next topic]."* Do not manufacture agreement. Skip optional follow-ups if time is short rather than rush the closing round.

**Boundaries:** arrange live-queue coverage and follow normal incident and safety procedures. No customer identifiers, raw logs, credentials, personal health disclosures, or live technical changes. Acknowledge sensitive personal concerns and offer the appropriate private support route; do not investigate them in the round table.

# 6. Close: key takeaways and lessons learned

## Key takeaways to connect back to the objectives

- **Different views are normal.** Start with the shared outcome, not a contest to win.
- **Understanding is not agreement.** Ask what the other person is protecting or needs.
- **Separate evidence from interpretation.** Challenge claims and impacts, not motives or identity.
- **Respect includes boundaries.** Pause or escalate appropriately when the interaction becomes unsafe.
- **Move forward honestly.** Use the right decision authority and preserve collaboration without forcing consensus.

## Lessons-learned conversation: minutes 80-87

Invite a brief closing round, with the option to pass: *"What is one idea you are taking away, or one colleague's perspective that changed or expanded your thinking?"* Keep contributions short so everyone has space. No writing or public commitment is required.

If helpful, ask: *"Where might this help in daily support work?"* or *"What still needs team or leadership support?"* Reflect actual participant insights, not anticipated outcomes.

## Examples to help the moderator recognize learning

| A participant might say... | Connection to the learning objective |
|---|---|
| "We were protecting different risks, not different customers." | Shared outcome: understand the concerns behind competing recommendations. |
| "Acknowledging a perspective did not mean agreeing with it." | Listening: create room for understanding without surrendering judgment. |
| "A clear decision route helped more than another round of debate." | Progress: clarify authority, concerns, and the next review point. |

## Moderator wrap-up: minutes 87-90

Summarize two or three themes heard, acknowledge differences, and return to the objectives. Do not promise actions you cannot authorize.

**Closing thought:** *"Constructive disagreement is not avoiding tension or making everyone agree. It is understanding the difference, protecting respect, and making the next decision clear."*

## Source and adaptation note

Inspired by Lynne Hurdle and Madecraft, *Communicating through Disagreement* (41m), assigned for RMP Day 10. Public listing and opening lesson *Having difficult conversations* reviewed November 2, 2026; the complete course was not reviewed. Questions, examples, and moderation guidance are original support adaptations, not a reproduction of the course's techniques.

RMP program materials | Course overview | Opening lesson